

Brookline Solid Waste Advisory Committee

Meeting Minutes for July 2, 2019

Submitted by John Shreffler

The meeting took place in the Public Health Building Library at 6:30 P.M.

Committee Members Present: John Dempsey (Chair), Deane Coady, John Shreffler, Susan Rittling, Mary Litterst

Committee Members Absent: Kathleen O'Connell, Clint Richmond

Public: Marga Dieter, Tom May (Save That Stuff), Karen Reid

Staff: Tom Segear, Ed Gilbert

Handouts: Agenda, Minutes of the June 4 meeting, June tonnages, Material Report, Draft Checklist for Launching a School Composting Pilot

Minutes from June 4th were reviewed and accepted as written, with corrections.

Discussion and introduction of Marga Dieter: Marga Dieter was introduced to our Committee. She's a member of Mothers Out Front and has been a regular volunteer at Brookline High School for the Food Waste Recycling Program. Tom May then asked a question as to why the Lincoln School was the model for our proposed food waste recycling guidelines. A discussion ensued as to the merits and debits of the anaerobic digester versus Black Earth soil producing food waste recycling models.

DPW Report:

- **Tonnages for June:** Trash tonnage for June was 739.80 tons, 6.5% decrease from June 2018. Total trash for FY 2019 was 8411 tons – up 1.1% from FY 2018. Recycling for June was 383.92 tons, a 9.7% decrease from June 2018. Total recycling for FY 2019 was 4780.22 tons, down 5.46% from FY 2018. Recycling processing cost for year was \$326,000, way up from previous year. Overall, recycling tonnages are going down, trash tonnages are going up.
- Ed Gilbert reported that ACR is creeping up, with recycling and solid waste running neck and neck. However, costs for solid waste are projected to increase from the current \$78 per ton to over \$100 per ton, because of the lack of geographically closer landfills and waste-to-energy facilities. Susan Rittling noted that lack of disposal sites increases the financial argument for composting.
- Ed Gilbert replied to a question raised by Tom May at the June 2019 SWAC meeting: Can the transfer station be used for composting? There was an agreement between neighbors, the MA DEP, and the Town that there was to be no composting at the Transfer Station: odors, pests, possible contamination of Sawmill Brook. For example, yard waste must be moved within one week. A discussion ensued as to whether yard waste collection should be limited to fewer months and whether residents should be charged extra for bulky items and electronics disposal. Were people from communities that charge for bulky items or that do not offer expansive yard waste collection leaving such things on the curb in Brookline for their convenience? Were contractors bring yard waste into Brookline from surrounding communities? John Dempsey

suggested that, if Brookline were to begin charging for bulky/electronic waste, we should agree with surrounding communities on establishing a uniform charge.

Food Waste Diversion at Schools and Guidelines for Starting School Food Waste Diversion

Deane Coady presented a Draft Checklist for Launching a School Composting Pilot, with the general idea being that SWAC would screen proposed school composting programs before they go on to the Director of Operations.

A discussion ensued as to possible refinements to the Draft Guidelines. The document was based on the highly successful pilot program at Lincoln School, which minimized contamination. Experience at Brookline High School showed a great deal of contamination. Tom May noted that the program at the High School fed into a system which was designed to handle contamination, with the machine separating and then grinding contaminants. Discussion then returned to the proposed guidelines which were read. John Dempsey noted the need for buy in from stakeholders, such as Principals, Vice-Principals, and Custodians. John Shreffler suggested need for a preface emphasizing necessity of awareness of local conditions, noting that attitudes of school administrators might differ, requiring different approaches to initiating such a program. Ed Gilbert noted that composting companies are necessary stakeholders.

Mary Litterst queried how our Committee would handle the proposed screening process. Would the full Committee need to meet? Should there be a Subcommittee? A possible workshop was discussed. Such a workshop could be handled through School PTOs. Deane Coady will revise Checklist and circulate it. The consensus was that a Subcommittee would be the most likely solution, with a motion being made, seconded, and passed to establish a subcommittee for this purpose. Ed Gilbert will report about Town procedures and requirements for subcommittees. John Dempsey and Deane Coady agreed to be on the subcommittee.

The next meeting will be on September 3, with no meeting to be held in August.

Meeting Adjourned at 7:50 PM.

FYI: Subcommittee meetings must be posted for the public. Notes must be taken and approved by the committee and then posted. Town staff are not required to attend but may if they wish or are asked to.